MODULE - V

APPLIED ETHICS

Objectives

1. To introduce subject matter of practical ethics

2. To describe nature of practical ethics

3. To describe scope of ethical theory in practice

4. To analyze the nature and scope of casuistry.

5. To distinguish the advantages and disadvantages of casuistry.

6. To familiarize Bio-ethics,Environmental ethics,Medical ethics,Professional ethics,Media ethics

5.1 There are three chief views as to the purpose of studying ethics.

a. Many thinkers maintain that ethics is purely theoretical study, seeking to understand the nature of morality, but with no purpose of having any affect whatever on the conduct of the man who studies it. F. H. Bradley, for example, denied the possibility of ethics providing 'an universal rule and canon for every possible case', and held at that casuistry, which is the attempt to apply ethical principles to the case of doubt in our practical experience, is 'unlovely in life and more unpleasant in decay, from which I myself should be loath to divide it'.

b. Other thinkers hold that the chief purpose of ethics is to influence our actual conduct. G. E. Moore calls casuistry 'the goal of ethical investigation', and holds that the aim of ethics is to apply its principles in such a way to guide men in the art of living.

c. Other thinkers, and probably they form the largest group; hold that while ethics is primarily a theoretical subject which is concerned with discovering the truth about moral matters, there must be in the course of ethical investigation a constant criticism of existing standards of morality, so that ethics becomes a practical subject almost in spite of itself. Those who take

the first view have been influenced by the disrepute into which casuistry has fallen, as Bradley's strong condemnation makes evident. They have also been affected by a common opinion that ethical theory makes no great difference to practice.

5.2 CASUISTRY

Casuistry is legitimate but an extremely difficult science. Casuistry is a reasonable extension of the province of ethics to examine how its principles work out in the actual circumstances of the moral life. There is indeed an advantage to the purely theoretical study of ethics in examining such applications. The engineer in applying to actual materials- steel, concrete, and the rest- the principles of dynamics, which he had studied in his theoretical text- books, that these principles, and may be led to new theoretical discoveries. Similarly the moralist, in applying his standards to actual cases, may find that these standards lead to contradictions, which suggest a revision in his statement of the moral standards. The most common objection to a general or dogmatic is likely enough to find defects in the formulation intuitionism like that described by Sidgwick has been that the rules discovered by intuition contradict one another in actual life; and this leads a moralist to reconsider and revise his theory. If ethical principles are not constantly checked up by seeing how they work in practice, the whole subject becomes a philosopher's fantasy away altogether from the lives of good and bad men.

The Influence of Ethical Theory on Practice Mackenzie argued that, ethical theories have no effect on particular moral decisions in practice. This is a difficult question to study, for often one cannot tell whether practice has influenced theory or theory has influenced practice. The moral theorist does not begin with abstract principles from which he deduces a theory. He begins with a common moral idea, of his time and place, which he examines, modifies in accordance with principles of consistency and his own intuitions, and arranges in a consistent system. To put it in another way, he does not impose new moral standards on existing moral opinions, but he extracts these moral standards from existing moral opinions, criticizing and modifying them in the process. The circumstances of his age and country are likely to influence not only the theories of the moralists but the common moral opinions with which he begins. One thing is certain and that is that moral practice is always influenced by more potent factors than moral theory. Custom, as expressed in institutions and in public opinion, is perhaps the most powerful influence. The individuals own intuitions, by which he sees the natural fittingness of things or the unique moral laws of nature so far as these are relevant to a particular case, are more powerful guides to conduct than the theories of the philosophers.

When we have allowed for all these admittedly potent factors we can still maintain that ethical theory does have bearing on ethical practice. The theory of utilitarian's was in part the product of an age in which new inventions and particularly new means of transport made the production of universal happiness a more attainable ideal, but the theory itself had intern a great influence on the movement s for social reform, for the spread of education, and for the development of the understating of economic laws in which the utilitarian leaders themselves took such a large share. Even in Bentham's own life his theory had practical effects in his schemes for education, such as the founding of University College, London, and his plans for international peace. The utilitarian's had certainly an advantage over most ethical schools in the matter of effecting practice; they had a slogan which the ordinary man thought that he understood; 'the greatest happiness of the greatest number'; and a slogan influences most men far more than abstract speculation. The evolutionary view, to some extend in its abstract Hegelian form through Carl Marx, but more commonly in the concrete biological form taught by Spencer, is perhaps still exerting a pernicious influence in popular pseudo scientific writings which take for granted that moral progress is inevitable, and so does not demand serious effort or self sacrificing zeal. The evolutionary theory of ethics is one of the intellectual factors, along with others both intellectual and non intellectual, that have produced a slackening of moral efforts in this age In our consideration of Spencer's theory we saw that, if the moral end is the preservation of life in the individual life or in the race, the consequence follows that the rule of eugenics are the most important among the rules of ethics. As a matter of fact eugenics, which claims to be a practical as well as a theoretical science, did it arise out of the evolutionary outlook of the later part of the 19thcentury, and it certainly has had some influence on morality. In discussing today whether divorce is ever morally justified some place would certainly be given to arguments from eugenics, such as the desirability for the future of the race of permitting divorce in order to prevent the birth of undesirable offspring.

Ethical theories do have a definite effect on moral practice, although often it takes place along time after the theory itself is given up by most competent moralists, because it has influence through its popular interprets whose ethical theories tend to be out of date.

Equality seems to be different. The change in attitudes to inequality-especially racial inequality-has been no less sudden and dramatic than the change in attitudes to sex, but it has been more complete. Racist assumptions shared by most Europeans at the turn of the century are now totally unacceptable, at least in public life. A poet could not now write of 'lesser breeds without the law', and retain– indeed enhance– his reputation, as Rudyard Kipling did in 1897. This does not mean that there are no longer any racists, but only that they must disguise their racism if their views and policies are to have any chance of general acceptance. The principle that all humans are equal is now part of the prevailing political and ethical orthodoxy. But what exactly, does it mean and why do we accept it?

When exploring the difficulty of grounding the principle of human equality beyond the obvious rejection of blatant discrimination. When applied to issues like affirmative action, opinions diverge: some argue equality requires favoring disadvantaged minorities, while others insist equality forbids any racial preference. This tension highlights the need to clarify what we mean when we claim all humans are equal. Critics note that humans are not equal in ability or circumstance, but John Rawls proposes that equality can rest on a "range property" shared equally by all—namely, moral personality. By this he means the capacity for a sense of justice and responsiveness to moral appeals. Rooted in the contract tradition of ethics, Rawls's view suggests that equality is based not on identical traits or outcomes but on the shared moral capacity that makes humans participants in the ethical community.

The essence of the principle of equal consideration of interests is that we give equal weight in our moral deliberations to the like interests of all those affected by our actions. This means that if only X and Y would be affected by a possible act and if X stands to lose more than Y stands to gain, it is better not to do the act. We cannot, if we accept the principle of equal consideration of interests, say that doing the act is better, despite the facts described, because we are more concerned about Y than we are about X. what the principle really amounts to is this: an interest is an interest, whoever's interest it may be. We can make this more concrete by considering a particular interest, say the interest we have in the relief of pain. Then the principle says that the ultimate moral reason for relieving pain is simply the undesirability of pain as such, and not the undesirability of X's pain, which might be different from the undesirability of Y's pain. Of course, X's pain might be more undesirable than Y's pain because it more painful, and then the principle of equal consideration would give greater weight to the relief of X's pain. Again, even where the pains are equal, other factors might be relevant, especially if others are affected. If there has been an earthquake we might give priority to the relief of a doctor's pain so she can treat other victims. But the doctor's pain itself counts only once, and with no added weighting. The principle of equal consideration of interests acts like a pair of scales, weighing interests impartially. True scales favour the side where the interest is stronger or where several interests combine to outweigh a smaller number of similar interests: but they take no account of whose interests they are weighing. The principle of equal consideration of interests is sometimes thought to be a purely formal principle, lacking in substance and too weak to exclude any inegalitarian practice. The principle of equal consideration of interests prohibits making our readiness to consider the interests of others depend on their abilities or other characteristics, apart from the characteristic of having interests. It is true that we cannot know where equal consideration of interests will lead us until we know what interests people have, and this may vary according to their abilities or other characteristics. Consideration of the interests of mathematically gifted children may lead us to teach them advanced mathematics at an early age, which for different children might be entirely pointless or positively harmful. So the principle of equal consideration of interests is strong enough to rule out an intelligence-based slave society as well as cruder forms of racism and sexism. It also rules out discrimination on the grounds of disability,

whether intellectual or physical, in so far as the disability is not relevant to the interests under consideration (as, for example, severe intellectual disability might be if we are considering a person's interest in voting in an election). The principle of equal consideration of interests therefore may be a defensible form of the principle that all humans are equal, a form that we can use in discussing more controversial issues about equality.

The opposition to genetic explanations of alleged racial differences in intelligence is only one manifestation of a more general opposition to genetic explanations in other socially sensitive areas. It closely parallels, for instance, initial feminist hostility to the idea that there are biological factors behind male dominance. (The second wave of the feminist movement seems to be more willing to entertain the idea that biological differences between the sexes are influential in, for example, greater male aggression and stronger female caring behavior). The opposition to genetic explanations also has obvious links with the intensity of feeling aroused by sociobiological approaches to the study of human behavior. The worry here is that if human social behavior is seen as deriving from that of other social mammals, we shall come to think of hierarchy, male dominance, and inequality as part of our evolved nature, and as unchangeable. More recently, the commencement of the international scientific project that is designed to map the human genome– that is, to provide a detailed scientific description of the genetic code typical of human beings– has attracted protests because of apprehension over what such a map might reveal about genetic differences between humans, and the use to which such information might be put in.

It would be inappropriate to attempt to assess the scientific merits of biological explanations of human behavior in general or of racial or sexual differences in particular. The concern is

rather with the implications of these theories for the ideal of equality. For this purpose it is not necessary for us to establish whether the theories are right. All we have to ask is: suppose that one ethnic group does turn out to have a higher average IQ than another, and that part of this difference has a genetic basis. Would this mean that racism is defensible, and we have to reject the principle of equality? A similar question can be asked about the impact of theories of biological differences between the sexes. In neither case does the question assume that the theories are sound. It would be most unfortunate if our skepticism about such things led us to neglect these questions and then unexpected evidence turned up confirming the theories, with the result that a confused and unprepared public took the theories to have implications for the ideal of equality that they do not have.Considering the implications of the

view that there is a difference in the average IQ of two different ethnic groups, and that genetic factors are responsible for at least a part of this difference. Then considering the impact of alleged differences in temperament and ability between the sexes.

Racial Differences and Racial Equality Let us suppose, just for the sake of exploring the consequences, that evidence accumulates supporting the hypothesis that there are differences in intelligence between the different ethnic groups of human beings. (We should not assume that this would mean that Europeans come out on top. As we have already seen, there is some evidence to the contrary.) What significance would this have for our views about racial equality?

First a word of caution. When people talk of differences in intelligence between ethnic groups, they are usually referring to differences in scores on standard IQ tests. Now 'IQ' stands for 'intelligence quotient' but this does not mean that an IQ test really measures what we mean by 'intelligence' in ordinary contexts. Obviously there is some correlation between the two: if schoolchildren regarded by their teachers as highly intelligent did not generally score better on IQ tests than schoolchildren regarded as below normal intelligence, the tests would have to be changed– as indeed they were changed in the past. But this does not show how close the correlation is, and since our ordinary concept of intelligence is vague, there is no way of telling. Some psychologists have attempted to overcome this difficulty by simply defining 'intelligence' as 'what intelligence tests measure', but this merely introduces a new concept of 'intelligence', which is easier to measure than our ordinary notion but may be quite different in meaning. Since 'intelligence' is a word in everyday use, to use the same word in a different sense is a sure path to confusion. Second, the fact that the average IQ of one racial group is a few points higher than that of another does not allow anyone to say that all members of the higher IQ group have higher IQs than all members of the lower IQ group– this is clearly false for any racial group– or that any particular individual in the higher IQ group has a higher IQ than a particular individual in the lower IQ group– this will often be false. The point is that these figures are averages and say nothing about individuals. There will be substantial overlap in IQ scores between the two groups. So whatever the cause of the difference in average IQs, it will provide no justification for racial segregation in education or any other field. It remains true that members of different racial groups must be treated as individuals, irrespective of their race. The third reason why the genetic hypothesis gives no support for racism is the most fundamental of the three. It is simply that, as we saw earlier, the principle of equality is not based on any actual equality that all people share. The only defensible basis for the principle of equality is equal consideration of interests, and also it is suggested that the most important human interests– such as the interest in avoiding pain, in developing one's

abilities, in satisfying basic needs for food and shelter, in enjoying warm personal relationships, in being free to pursue one's projects without interference, and many others– are not affected by differences in intelligence. We can be even more confident that they are not affected by differences in IQ.

Thomas Jefferson, who drafted the ringing assertion of equality with which the American Declaration of independence begins, knew this. Jefferson was right. Equal status does not depend on intelligence. Racist who maintain the contrary are in peril of being forced to kneel before the next genius they encounter. These three reasons suffice to show that claims that for genetic reasons one racial group is not as good as another at IQ tests do not provide grounds for denying the moral principle that all humans are equal. The third reason, however, has further ramifications that we shall follow up after discussing differences between the sexes.

5.3 BIOETHICS

Bioethics is an interdisciplinary field of study dealing with practical ethical issues roughly at the intersection of morality, medicine, and the life sciences. Within philosophy, bioethics is one of several different areas of applied ethics, a domain within general normative ethics. The term "bioethics" was coined in 1970, but the development of bioethics as a discipline may be

dated to the late 1960sor early 1970s, depending on which historical markers are used. Bioethics as a sub-discipline of philosophy and applied ethics and as an element in education for the health professions has undergone astounding growth in the last few decades. It has become an institution in its own right, with a large number of journals, books, research enters, professional organizations, international conferences, courses, and discussions throughout the world. The task of bioethics is to resolve rationally the ethical problems faced by health care practitioners. Quite often the strategy used will be that of articulating or positing overarching principles and then applying these by a kind of deductive process to the situation which has given rise to the problem. That bioethics is a principle-based, rationally grounded decision procedure for solving moral quandaries in health care. Accordingly, bioethics addresses only a part of the normative structure of the practice of health care: namely, the explicit and public elements of decision procedures that can be articulated as arguments based on principles. the most controlled view, bioethics simply reduces to biomedical ethics, which comprehends ethical issues concerning to the practice of medicine broadly understood and the pursuit of medical research. the second understanding, bioethics encompasses, in addition to biomedical ethics, ethical issues related to the life sciences and technologies. Biotechnology is the application of science and technology to living organisms and their parts, or products and models of living organisms, in the hope of producing understanding, goods, or services. Biotechnology is multidisciplinary in that it involves many different disciplines, all the pure and applied sciences in fact, and interdisciplinary in that all these sciences and technologies work together to achieve biotechnological ends. The 'bio' bit is important because, in biotechnology, these different sciences and technologies are all applied to biological organisms: to living organisms, their parts and products, and to models of such organisms. Biology is central to the pursuit of biotechnological ends because biotechnology is the application of science and technology to biological organisms. Bioethics is the discipline that studies the actions permitted by biotechnology– actions like cloning or genetic engineering– and asks whether or not these actions are morally acceptable, and if so, how we should manage them socially to promote citizens' welfare, protect their rights and treat them fairly One of the interesting dimensions of bioethics today is that it is becoming increasingly more international. From where it started the United States and Western Europe– bioethics has spread to other countries but with a more global perspective. Medical research is increasingly multicentre and international, with growing numbers of research subjects recruited in developing countries. Also, health care practices are global, but guidelines and legal contexts differ and are sometimes absent. As the example of human cloning demonstrates, when a new technology has been developed in one country, it is possible to apply the technology everywhere, even if some countries want to ban its use. Global postmodern cosmopolis is unfolding during rapid evolutionary and social changes co-constructed by science, technology, and the restructuring of global capital. Were people are quickly morphing into a new biological and social existence that is gradually mediated and shaped by computers, mass media, and biotechnology, all driven by the logic of capital and powerful emergent technoscience. It's the era where life can be created and redesigned and

genetic codes can be edited like a digital text, the distinction between “natural” and “artificial” has become greatly complex. This techno-culture creates a fictitious environment for us. It also creates innovative moral dilemmas like cloning, largescale abortions, euthanasia, capital punishment, sexuality, and marriage. The new techniques of biotechnological manipulation call into question existing definitions of life and death which demands a rethinking of fundamental notions of ethics and moral value. Experimentation on animals and humans is accelerated because genetic engineering and cloning are developed for commercial purposes, anticipating enormous profits on the horizon for the biotech industry.

5.3.1 ABORTION -The practice of abortion dates back to ancient times. Pregnancies were terminated owing to several kinds of prejudices as fear of female children and the incurring burden. Abortion laws and their enforcement have fluctuated through various eras. Many early laws and church doctrine focused on "quickening," when the initial motion of the fetus can be felt by the pregnant woman, as a way to differentiate when abortion became impermissible. In the 18th–19th centuries various doctors, clerics, and social reformers successfully pushed for an all-out abortion ban. In the 20th century various women's rights groups, doctors, and social reformers successfully repealed abortion bans. While abortion remains legal in many Western countries, it is regularly subjected to legal challenges by pro-life groups. The first recorded evidence of induced abortion is from the Egyptian Ebers Papyrus in 1550 BC. The early Greek classical texts show methods and practice of abortion in Greek and Roman. Abortion, as a gynaecological procedure, was primarily the province of women who were either midwives or well-informed laypeople. In his Theaetetus, Plato mentions a midwife's right to induce abortion in the early stages of pregnancy. The Hippocratic Oath forbids the use of pessaries to induce abortion; it did not prohibit abortion. Modern scholarship suggests that pessaries were banned because they were reported to cause vaginal ulcers. Soranus, a 2nd-century Greek physician, recommended abortion in cases involving health complications as well as emotional immaturity and provided detailed suggestions in his work Gynaecology. Diuretics, emmenagogues, enemas, fasting, and bloodletting were prescribed as safe abortion methods, although Soranus advised against the use of sharp instruments to induce miscarriage, due to the risk of organ perforation. Despite the inherent negativity of any abortion, the question remains whether some forms of abortion may be morally permissible or occur without anyone being morally responsible. We must, therefore, consider four distinct types of abortion:

1. spontaneous abortion, also know as “miscarriage;”

2. directly intended abortion;

3. indirectly intended abortion;

4. abortion by means of an abortifacient contraceptive.

A spontaneous abortion is the only form of abortion for which nobody may be morally responsible. It is typically caused by some natural factor that is not under anyone's control which results in either an embryo failing to implant in the uterus or a fetus dislodging from the uterus sometime after implantation. Directly intended abortion occurs when a woman or some other agent desires to end a pregnancy and does so through either a surgical procedure or a chemical inducement.There are several views on the wrong or right of abortion. In prolife view it states that abortion is wrong because it is the killing of an innocent person, it asserts that

(1) a human embryo is a human being;

(2) it is wrong to take a human life;

(3) therefore, it is wrong to "destroy" an embryo. The pro-choice view and feminist views support that abortion are morally permissible whenever the mother chooses it. Abortion arguments that emphasize the moral status of the fetus are concerned with a broad range of ethical issues. They ask such questions as: Is the fetus a human being? A person? At the bottom, these questions point toward the ontological and moral status of the fetus. Ontology means "theory of being," so the ontological question asks what sort of being the fetus is, what kind of value or moral status does the developing fetus have? The ontological question is connected to the moral question of the moral status of the being. What we want to know is both what kind of a being the fetus is and what sort of value that kind of being has. According to one point of view, it is being human that counts— being a member of the human species. Now, using this criterion, we might note that human fetuses are members of the human species and conclude that they have equal moral status with all other human beings. Based on the notion that all humans have equal moral worth. This has not always been the case, for example when children or women were treated more like property than as human beings with equal and full moral status. By "special moral status," we might mean various things. Among the most important would be a status such that the fetus would be thought to have something like a right to life. If this were the case, then abortion would become morally problematic. Potentiality means "power." According to this criterion, all beings that have the power to develop certain key characteristics have full moral worth. Thus, if a particular fetus had the potential for developing the requisite mental capacities, then this fetus would have full moral status. Some critics of abortion argue that abortion is wrong because it prevents a being (the fetus) from actualizing its potential. philosopher Don Marquis argues that it is seriously wrong to kill children and infants because we presume that children and infants have "futures of value. According to Marquis, abortion is wrong for a similar reason, which is that it deprives the fetus of obtaining the future good it would have if it were left alone and allowed to be born. If a rather high level of reasoning is required before an individual has the requisite moral status, then newborns probably would not be included, as well as many others. The claim that even newborns lack the high-level capacities relevant to full moral status is defended by the

philosopher Mary AnneWarren. According to this view, although the fetus, newborn infant, and extremely young child are human beings biologically, they are not yet persons or beings with the requisite moral status. They are not yet members of the moral community. There may be good reasons to treat them well and with respect, but it is not because they are persons with rights. In applying this criterion to fetal development, the conclusion would be that the early-term fetus has less moral value or moral status than the late-term fetus. Such an approach would parallel the idea, found in the law, that the state can regulate late-term abortions but not early-term abortions. Moderately serious interests of the pregnant woman or society could override the interests or claims of the early-term fetus, but it would take more serious interests to override the claims of the late-term fetus. In the end, according to this view, when potentiality is sufficiently actualized, the fetus or infant has as much right as any other person. An alternative approach along these lines is associated with the work of philosopher Rosalind Hursthouse, who uses virtue ethics to consider the topic of abortion. Hursthouse is critical of those who have abortions for frivolous reasons, but she argues that there may be some virtuous reasons that a woman could choose to have an abortion. If the fetus does not have the requisite moral status, then abortion is probably morally permissible. If it is considered to be a person, then abortion is morally problematic. the whole weight of the moral judgment about abortion on what status the fetus does or does not have. Finally, remember that not everything that we consider immoral can (or should) be made illegal. Thus, even if abortion were in some cases thought to be immoral, one would need to give further reasons about the purpose of the law to conclude that it also ought to be illegal. At the same time, we must ask if the only reason to make something illegal is if it is immoral. There may be cases when we want to permit people the liberty to choose for themselves about morally controversial issues.

5.3.2 Euthanasia –

Euthanasia is the practice of voluntarily having a medically assisted death. It is illegal in most countries. Euthanasia may be conducted with consent- voluntary euthanasia- or without consent- involuntary euthanasia. Since involuntary euthanasia is conducted without an individual's specifically given acquiescence, while voluntary euthanasia is euthanasia with the person’s direct consent it is still controversial for reasons discussed below. Euthanasia may be conducted passively, non-aggressively, and aggressively. Passive euthanasia entails the withholding of common treatments knowing that it may also result in death. Aggressive euthanasia entails the use of lethal substances or forces to kill and is the most controversial means. The term euthanasia comes from the Greek words "eu” and “thanatos” which combined means “well death” or "dying well". Hippocrates mentions euthanasia in the Hippocratic Oath, which was written between 400 and 300 B.C. The original Oath states: “To please no one will I prescribe a deadly drug nor give advice which may cause his death.” Despite this, the ancient Greeks and Romans generally did not believe that life needed to be

preserved at any cost and were, in consequence, tolerant of suicide in cases where no relief could be offered to the dying or, in the case of the Stoics and Epicureans, where a person no longer cared for his life. An influential utilitarian philosopher, Peter Singer, has argued that it is possible to imagine killing a disabled newborn and "replacing" it with another healthy baby in a subsequent pregnancy to achieve a net outcome of happiness. Singer notes that we allow women to abort disabled fetuses, and he sees very little difference between abortion and euthanasia for infants. Singer argues that "killing a disabled infant is not morally equivalent to killing a person. Very often it is not wrong at all." In Canada, patients have the right to refuse medical treatment, although even with their consent, their physician is unable to assist the patient with suicide. The Netherlands is the only country in the world where euthanasia is openly practiced. It is not allowed by statute, but the law accepts a standard defense from doctors that have adhered to official guidelines. Large number of people especially religious people against these.

5.3.2.1Passive euthanasia - refers to withholding or withdrawing treatment and letting a patient die. Thus, passive euthanasia can also be described as "letting die" or "allowing to die." Sometimes this is referred to as "letting nature take its course." This might include either withdrawing care /as in removing a feeding tube/ or withholding care /as in not prescribing antibiotics to cure an infection. Often patients will decide in advance whether they want to be allowed to die from the progress of a fatal disease or medical complications after surgery. it has been acknowledged that patients have a right to refuse treatment. In these cases, the decision is made voluntarily. when the patient has not consented in advance and is unable to provide consent next relatives are consulted to decide what the patient would have wanted in terms of treatment.

5.3.2.2 Active euthanasia - refers to a more active intervention that aims to bring about the death of a person—a lethal injection, for example. active euthanasia involves taking a step that directly brings about a person's death. In the past, it used to be called "mercy killing." Drugs are the most common means. Rather than letting a person die, these means are used to kill the person. In the United States, active euthanasia is legally prohibited. However, as we've noted, in the Netherlands active euthanasia is permitted. Critics worry that this practice opens the door to killing those who feel they have become a financial burden on their families or who merely fear future suffering. Physician-assisted suicide is yet another thing— as the physician merely prescribes the lethal medication without administering it herself. A further set of concepts focuses on whether euthanasia is given to those who request it and consent to it or not. Voluntary euthanasia implies that the patient consents. Causing death with the patient's consent, knowingly and freely given, the laws in Belgium and the Netherlands require that the patient request euthanasia. These laws primarily focus on regulating voluntary euthanasia. There are three types of voluntary euthanasia.

1. **Voluntary active euthanasia:** The person who is dying says, "Give me the fatal dose."

2. **Voluntary passive euthanasia**, withholding ordinary measures: The person says, “Don’t use lifesaving or life prolonging medical measures even though the likely results of using them would be good and the costs or burdens minimal, because I want to die.”

3. **Voluntary passive euthanasia**, withholding extraordinary measures: The person says, “Don’t use those medical measures because the chances of benefit in terms of saving or extending my life would be small, the burdens too great, or both.”

5.3.2.3 Nonvoluntary euthanasia describes euthanasia for those who are unable to give consent infants or those with severe brain damage. for example, when a feeding tube is removed from a patient in a persistent vegetative state.

1**. Nonvoluntary active euthanasia**: Others decide to give the person a fatal drug overdose.
2. **Non voluntary passive euthanasia**, withholding ordinary measures: Others decide not to use lifesaving or life-prolonging medical measures even though the likely results of using them would be good and the costs or burdens minimal.

3. **Non voluntary passive euthanasia**, withholding extraordinary measures: Others decide not to use those medical measures because the chances of benefit—saving or extending life—are small, the burdens are too great, or both. Involuntary euthanasia implies that the killing is done in violation of the patient’s will. There is no moral justification for involuntary euthanasia, which can also be called murder. There is some fear, however, that that the legalization of euthanasia might create a slippery slope from voluntary euthanasia toward involuntary euthanasia—that is, toward letting people die or actively killing them against their will. involuntary euthanasia involves the high cost of health care at the end of life. Some people can benefit from the death of a patient; family members who worry about losing an inheritance or paying for medical bills, and insurance companies who have related financial concerns. a utilitarian argument that attempts to justify involuntary euthanasia.

From this perspective, voluntariness matters morally only to the extent that it affects human happiness and welfare. Respecting people’s own choices about how they will die surely would have some beneficial consequences. For example, when people know that they will be allowed to make decisions about their own lives and not be forced into things against their will, then they may gain a certain peace of mind. The idea is that autonomy is good in itself and therefore carries heavy moral weight. We like to think of ourselves, at least ideally, as masters of our fate. According to Kant, autonomy makes morality possible. His famous phrase “an ought implies a can” indicates that if and only if we can or are free to act in certain ways can we be commanded to do so. According to a Kantian deontological position, persons are unique in being able to choose freely, and this capacity for choice ought to be respected. Nevertheless, in many euthanasia cases, a person’s mental capability and thus autonomy are compromised by fear, lack of understanding, dependency, and hopelessness. Illness and dependency can make a person more subject to undue influence or coercion.

5.3.2.4 TAKINGLIFE: THE EMBRYO AND THE FETUS

The Problem ethical issues are as bitterly fought over today as abortion, and, while the pendulum has swung back and forth, neither side has had much success in altering the opinions of its opponents. Until 1967, abortion was illegal in almost all the Western democracies except Sweden and Denmark. Then Britain changed its law to allow abortion on board social grounds, and in the 1973 case of Roe v Wade, the United States

Supreme Court held that women have a constitutional right to an abortion in the first six months of pregnancy. Western European nations, including Roman Catholic countries like Italy, Spain and France, all liberalized their abortion laws. Only the republic of Ireland held out against the trend. Opponents of abortion did not give up. In the United States, conservative Presidents have changed the composition of the Supreme Court, which in turn has nibbled around the margins of the Roe v Wade decision, allowing states to restrict, in various ways, access to abortion. Outside the United States, the issue of abortion re-surfaced in Eastern Europe after the collapse of communism. The communist states had allowed abortion, but as nationalist and religious forces gathered strength, there were strong moves in countries like Poland for the re-introduction of restrictive laws. Since West Germany had more restrictive laws than East Germany, the need to introduce a single law for a united Germany also caused an intense debate. In 1978 the birth of Louise Brown raised a new issue about the status of early human life. For Louise Brown was the first fertilized outside a human body. The success of Robert Edwards and Patrick Steptoe in demonstrating the possibility of in vitro fertilization, or IVF, was based on several years of experimentation on early human embryos– none of which had survived. IVF is now a routine procedure for certain types of infertility, and has given rise to thousands of healthy babies. To reach this point, however, many more embryos had to be destroyed in experiments, and further improvement of IVF techniques will require continued experimentation. Perhaps more significant still, for the long-term, are the possibilities for other forms of experimentation opened up by the existence of a viable embryo outside the human body. Embryos can now be frozen and stored for many years before being thawed and implanted in a woman. Normal children develop from these embryos, but the technique means that there are large numbers of embryos now preserved in special freezers around the world. (At the time of writing there were about 11,000frozen embryos in Australia

alone.) Because the IVF procedure often produces more embryos than can safely be transferred to the uterus of the woman from whom the egg came, many of these frozen embryos will never be wanted, and presumably will either be destroyed, be donated for research, or given to other infertile couples. Other new technologies loom just a little way ahead. Embryos can be screened for genetic abnormalities, and then discarded if such abnormalities are found. Edwards has predicted that it will become scientifically feasible to grow embryos in vitro to the point at which, about 17 days after fertilization, they develop blood stem cells, which could be used to treat various now-lethal blood diseases. Others, speculating about the further future, have asked if one day we will have banks of embryos or fetuses to provide organs for those who need them. Abortion and destructive embryo experimentation pose difficult ethical issues because the development of the human being is a gradual process. If we take the fertilized egg immediately after conception, it is hard to get upset about its death. The fertilized egg is a single cell. After several days, it is still only a tiny cluster of cells without a single anatomical feature of the being it will later become. The cells that will eventually become the embryo proper are at this stage indistinguishable from the cells that will become the placenta and amniotic sac. Up to about 14 days after fertilization, we cannot even tell if the embryo is going to be one or two individuals, because splitting can take place, leading to the formation of identical twins. At 14 days, the first anatomical feature, the so-called primitive streak, appears in the position in which the backbone will later develop. At this point the embryo could not possibly be conscious or feel pain. At the other extreme is the adult human being. To kill a human adult is murder, and is unhesitatingly and universally condemned. Yet there is no obvious sharp line that divides the fertilized egg from the adult. Hence the problem. Beginning the discussion of abortion states the position of those opposed to abortion, which can be referred to as the conservative position. Then examining some of the standard liberal responses, and show why they are inadequate. Finally one can use our earlier discussion of the value of life to approach the issue from a broader perspective. In contrast to the common opinion in the moral question about abortion is a dilemma with no solution,so at least within the bounds of non religious ethics, there is a clear-cut answer and those who take a different position are completely mistaken.

On this issue the conservative position if difficult to shake. The conservative points to the continuum between the fertilized egg and child, and challenges the liberal to point to any stage in this gradual process that marks a morally significant dividing line. Unless there is such a line, the conservative says, we must either upgrade the status of the earliest embryo to that of the child, or downgrade the status of the child to that of the embryo; but no one wants to allow children to be dispatched on the request of their parents, and so the only tenable position is to grant the fetus the protection we now grant the child. It is true that there is no

morally significant dividing line between fertilized egg and child? Those commonly suggested are: birth, viability, quickening, and the onset of consciousness. Let us consider these in turn. Birth is the most visible possible dividing line, and the one that would suit liberals best. It coincides to some extent with our sympathies– we are less disturbed at the destruction of a fetus we have never seen than at the death of a being we can all see, hear and cuddle. But is this enough to make birth the line that decides whether a being may or may not be killed? The conservative can plausibly reply that the fetus/baby is the same entity, whether inside or outside the womb, with the same human features (whether we can see them or not) and the same degree of awareness and capacity for feeling pain. A prematurely born infant may well be less developed in these respects than a fetus nearing the end of its normal term. It seems peculiar to hold that we may not kill the premature infant, but may kill the more developed fetus. The location of a being– inside or outside the womb– should not make that much difference to the wrongness of killing it. Viability If birth does not mark a crucial moral distinction, should we push the line back to the time at which the fetus could survive outside the womb? This overcomes one objection to taking birth as the decisive point, for it treats the viable fetus on a par with the infant, born prematurely, at the same stage of development. Viability is where the United States Supreme Court drew the line in Roe v.Wade. The Court held that the state has a legitimate interest in protecting potential life, and this interest becomes 'compelling' at viability 'because the fetus then presumably has the capability of meaningful life outside the mother's womb'. Therefore statutes prohibiting abortion after viability would not, the Court said, be unconstitutional. But the judges who wrote the majority decision gave no indication why the mere capacity to exist outside the womb should make such a difference to the state's interest in protecting potential life. After all, if we talk, as the Court does, of potential human life, then the nonviable fetus is as much a potential adult human as the viable fetus.

5.4 ENVIRONMENTAL ETHICS

According to Paul Taylor, environmental ethics is concerned with the moral relations that hold between humans and the natural world. Rather than thinking in terms of one-way causal interactions, it is to think of the evolution of an interlinked system over time. The questions about the human relation to the natural world increased attention as a result of the growing environmental consciousness and social movements of the 1960s. It was in the early 1970s that environmental ethics was made a start as the subfield of philosophy. It was through the works of Richard Routley, John Passmore, Arne Naess, and Holmes Rolston that environmental ethics arose as a branch of philosophy. Environmental ethics was in a way for liberating

philosophy from the narrowness and overspecialization to which it had fallen. Today there is a need for an interdisciplinary approach to knowledge in countering the issue of global climate change. It is a fact that human issues cannot be solved without employing the resources of humanities, especially philosophy. Rethinking of the most basic thoughts regarding nature has to be the concern of philosophers. This refers to the proper relationship between humans and nature.

A small group of philosophers turned their attention to the questions concerning the human obligation to nature, it was due to manhandling of nature that prompted philosophers towards the need for Environmental ethics.

It may require the restructuring of the global economic system that a solution regarding the problem posed due to rival views of theories of ecological problems is reached. It is the Brundtland report of 1987, where policies of sustainable development is presented which seek to address these combining development and sustainability Biocentrism problems by It is the view that each living thing matters in its own right, biocentrism is considered a form of individualism.

Biocentrism is a life-centered outlook, in this view moral standing of all living creatures is accepted and rejects the view that humanity only matters. Some thinkers on whom the influence could be seen are Albert Schweitzer, Mahatma Gandhi. Schweitzer believed in the "reverence for life" and Gandhi regarded the destruction of even vegetable life as himsa. The important tenets of Biocentrism area] All living creatures have a good of their own and it is for their own sake that they warrant moral attention b] Attainment of their good is intrinsically valuable. Arne Naess included living systems within the scope of Biocentrism. To say that even ecosystems and habitats have a good of their own and having a moral standing is classified as ecocentrism. It is in individual creatures that Bio centrists locate moral standing. Bio centrists respect for system is because it makes possible life within them rather than respecting in themselves.

5.4.1 ANTHROPOCENTRICISM:

In the Anthropocentric view, it is human beings and their interest which matter morally in their own right, it is in so far as it affects human beings that everything else matters. It is also possible that the even without positing intrinsic value to things in natural world anthropocentricism can be rejected. It means though its value does not depend on serving human interest it can serve interest of some kind. It can be stated that only instrumental value of nature can be attributed in the anthropocentric view. In the non-anthropocentric view natural world and its parts have value in their own right independent of their effects on human beings. To have value on its own right is to claim that it has intrinsic value. According to many theorists to discover the intrinsic value in nature is a defining problem for environmental ethics. Ethical issues in development; Sustainable development; Sustainable development The

definition for sustainable development according to the world commission for environment and development is the "development that meets the needs of the present without compromising the ability of future generations to meet their own needs". This is comparable with J.S. Mill's conception of liberty which states that the pursuit of liberty must be compatible with the similar liberty for all. According to the principle of sustainable development, the pursuit of quality of life must be compatible with the quality of life of all including future generations. It is the Brundtland report of 1987, where policies of sustainable development is presented which seek to address these problems by combining development and sustainability In a sustainable development scenario, there is the continuous maintenance of the quality of the environment for many years. The degradation of the environment and its resources is not allowed. There is a limited way in which natural resources are used, also the constituents of the environment are used for future generations hence producing a balanced ecosystem. Aspects of the ecosystem such as economy, environment, and equity should be considered while taking development decisions. Intrinsic and instrumental value; Intrinsic value There should be at least some part of the natural world to which environmental ethics should ascribe intrinsic value. Anthropocentrism holds that view that human beings have value in its right while everything has value in so far it benefits human beings. In the non-anthropocentric view, the natural world and its parts have value on its own right independent of its effect on human beings. Australian philosopher Routley speculates a situation in which the surviving a catastrophe tries to ensure the elimination of all living things including forests and ecosystems after their demise. So from the Anthropocentric perspective, the last man would do any destructive act, since it is not morally wrong since the well-being of human beings is not in question. But according to Routley, there is a moral intuition that these last acts are morally wrong since the objects in the environment have an intrinsic value irrespective of being human being. So Routley states that traditional western moral thinking did not allow natural things to have intrinsic value. Having intrinsic value for the natural world is a claim for having a value in its own right. When natural world is treated only as a means for human needs or ends then it is claimed to possess instrumental value. What stimulated many writers to have obligation to species, communities and ecosystems ie., for ecology as a whole not only individual constituents was influenced by Leopold. Leopold held that land as a whole is object of our moral concern.

5.4.2 DEEP ECOLOGY:

Arne Naess is a Norwegian philosopher, according to Naess there is required a shift in metaphysical and epistemological assumptions in response to problems posed to the environment. What is required in response to the environmental problems is a shift in metaphysical and epistemological assumptions. According to Naess all living things have an equal right to flourish which is called 'biospherical egalitarianism'. There is a need to radically rethink our modes of life our economic activity, political institutions and our acceptance of human population growth. In Naess's revised understanding of the self, self is seen as relational rather than discrete or bounded, in which it is seen as including the aspects of

natural world rather than distinct from natural world. With this extended conception of self at place environmental ethics is seen as project of self realisation. Naess does not consider human being as an individual possessing a separate essence, this separation of human beings from the other things of nature can lead to selfishness to other people and other things in nature. For countering this he proposes a relational "total-fied image" of the world. In which individuals or organisms are "knots" in the bio spherical net. It is by relations to other things in the world that the identity is constituted. The core principle involved in deep ecology is the claim that along with humanity the living environment as a whole has the same right to live and flourish. The concern of deep ecology is regarding the fundamental questions about the impacts of human life as one part of ecosphere, it tries to avoid anthropocentric environmentalism, concern of which is environment conservation for exploitation by and for human needs. This philosophy makes us understand how different parts of the ecosystem function as a whole unit. It provides a more holistic view of the world we live in. It was Arne Naess who coined the term " deep ecology" is in 1973 According to him, an ecological science with ecological wisdom is required for answering ethical questions regarding how we should live. For enabling this it requires deep experience, deep commitment and deep questioning. This is an interconnected system each gives rise and supports other; the entire system is called ecosophy.

5.4.3 We can look in to an Environmental issue and how Peter Singer evaluates the problem

By examining Peter Singer's Practical Ethics one can understand how ethics relates to environment. An example being of the environmental issue of Franklin river dam case.

The Franklin River dam case (which your excerpt reshapes into a hypothetical) is a classic example of a clash between utilitarian values (economic growth, jobs, energy security) and non-utilitarian values (preservation of rare species, wilderness, intrinsic environmental worth).

We can find that there are two competing values in the Dam case,by examining the ethical conceptions involved in Utilitarian and non utilitarian claims we can understand how these view points apply in real world scenario. If we comply by the utilitarian consideration we can estimate that it will provide short term employment for 1000 people also there is long term energy security for the state.It has the potential for industrial growth and further jobs also economic benefits distributed across society.

By taking the non-utilitarian consideration in to account,it will result in loss of rare Huon Pine trees over 1000 years old, there is also destruction of habitat for endangered marsupial mouse there is also unknown ecological losses.It also poses threat to irreplaceable cultural and environmental heritage. According to Peter Singer equal consideration of interests must be applied though human interest in jobs and energy security are of priority. But the sufferring or destruction of non human animals,plants and ecosystem counts. The principle of equal consideration doesn't mean identical treatment, but it does mean we can't dismiss nonhuman interests as irrelevant. From the view point of utilitarianism building the Dam is good if the aggregate benefits outweigh the harms. Environmental ethics and rights-based views (like intrinsic value of species or ecosystems) might argue the dam should not be built, even if it's economically beneficial. So the question remains that whether we are giving disproportionate weight to human convenience over non human survival.

If we look in to the historical roots of the Western attitudes toward nature ,let us have a comparision.

Western tradition origins:

o Hebrew (Biblical) view: Humans are given dominion over nature (Genesis), placing them at the center of moral significance.

o Greek (Aristotelian) view: Nature exists for human use; humans are the telos (end) of creation.

Contrast with other traditions:

o In India and other non-Western traditions, nature often has intrinsic moral or spiritual significance. Humans are not the sole moral focus.

Modern implications:

o The Western blend (Hebrew + Greek) shaped a worldview where wilderness is valued only insofar as it serves human needs.

o This explains why dam proponents emphasize jobs and income, while opponents emphasize preservation — they're appealing to fundamentally different value systems

So from this Singer wants us to see that the debate is not between economics and recreation,but about the deeply embedded cultural values. So we can understand that wilderness have a value beyond human utility such as for species survival,ecological integrity and human experience.

In Singers analysis of the biblical idea of dominion, it can be understood that the biblical ideas shaped the Western attitude towards nature. As mentioned in the genesis passage that human's are created in God's image and given authority over "every living thing".

According to some "dominion" should mean stewardship which means caring for creation responsibly. The flood narrative reinforces the idea that God can destroy animals to punish humans

- After the Flood, dominion is restated in harsher terms: animals are to fear humans, and are “delivered into your hands.”
- This suggests exploitation, not stewardship, was the intended meaning.

From the view point of the early Christian thinkers like Augustine they shared an anthropocentric view, reinforcing the idea that animals mattered in so far as they served human purposes.

This tradition entrenched the idea that:

- Nature has instrumental value (valuable only for human use).
- Wilderness preservation or animal protection is not a moral priority unless it benefits humans.
- This worldview underlies modern conflicts like the dam case: jobs and growth are seen as more important than rare species or ecosystems
- Singer challenges this anthropocentrism by insisting that animal suffering and ecological destruction matter morally.
- Kant, however, still grounds duties in human freedom and rationality, so animals and wilderness don’t have rights in themselves — though he does argue we have indirect duties (e.g., cruelty to animals corrupts human morality).

Summary of the Dominant Western Tradition

- Humans are the sole moral centre.
- Nature exists for human use (food, clothing, tools, recreation).
- No moral wrong in destroying plants or animals, unless it harms humans.
- Wilderness preservation or animal protection is not a moral duty in itself.

Singer is building the case that even if you accept a human-centered ethic, the argument for preservation becomes powerful when you factor in future generations. The dam's benefits are temporary; the destruction of wilderness is permanent.

Singer's Critique

- Wilderness and ancient forests are priceless and irreplaceable.
- Applying a discount rate to them gives the wrong answer:

o No amount of future money can buy back the continuity of a virgin forest once destroyed.

o Short-term gains (jobs, exports, cheaper paper) cannot outweigh permanent loss.

- Therefore, justifying destruction of wilderness purely on economic grounds is unsound.

Ethical Implications

- Any justification for cutting or drowning forests must account for:

o Long-term value to future generations.

o Unique scenic or biological significance.

- As wilderness dwindles, every remaining part becomes significant.
- This reframes wilderness as world heritage — something inherited from ancestors and owed to descendants

According to Singer animal suffering ecological destruction matter morally thereby challenges anthropocentricism.

Immanuel Kant grounds duties in human rationality and freedom,so animals and wilderness dont have rights in themselves,but he insists that we have indirect duties,an example would be cruelty to animals corrupts human morality.

Aristotle believed in the ideology that plants exists for animals and animals for humans's.So every thing in nature has purpose,and that purpose is ultimately human use.

Augustine suggested that refraining from killing animals or destroying plants was not virtuous was actually misguided.

Aquinas adopted Aristotle's view almost word for word in the summa theologica.He linked it with the genesis,reinforcing divine sanction for human dominion.Thereby there was no posibility of sins against animals or nature .

Summary of the Dominant Western Tradition

- Humans are the sole moral center.
- Nature exists for human use (food, clothing, tools, recreation).
- No moral wrong in destroying plants or animals, unless it harms humans.
- Wilderness preservation or animal protection is not a moral duty in itself.

Core Features of the Tradition

- Anthropocentrism: Humans are the only morally significant beings.
- Instrumental value of nature: Plants, animals, and wilderness matter only insofar as they serve human needs.
- No intrinsic wrong in destruction: Killing animals or destroying forests is not sinful unless it harms humans.
- Religious and philosophical reinforcement:
  - Genesis grants dominion.
  - Augustine and Aquinas interpret dominion as license, not stewardship.

Singer also applies aesthetic and cultural values on to the case of wilderness preservation,along the long term and intergenerational ones

- Future generations and wilderness appreciation:

o It's possible they might prefer malls and virtual entertainment, but the trend has been the opposite.

o Nations with little wilderness left often value it most.

o Wilderness is prized for beauty, recreation, scientific knowledge, and simply for existing untouched.

o If future generations meet basic needs, they will likely continue to value wilderness.

- **AESTHETIC VALUE:**

o Arguments for wilderness beauty are sometimes dismissed as "merely aesthetic."

o Singer counters: we preserve art treasures (e.g., paintings in the Louvre) at immense cost, refusing to trade them for economic gain.

o Why should wilderness — a natural masterpiece — be valued less than human art?

- **PERSONAL TESTIMONY:**

o Singer compares his own experience of great art galleries with wilderness.

o He finds wilderness at least as valuable, perhaps more so, because it is unique, irreplaceable, and not human-made.

Human centered ethic and environmental values:

o A human centered ethic does not imply that economic growth is always more important than preservation.

o Exploiting irreplaceable resources may bring short term gains, but at a long term cost borne by future generations.

o Thus, even anthropocentric reasoning supports strong environmental priorities.

5.5 Medical ethics

The main objective of medical ethics is to provide ethical understandings to students in the field of medicine and clinical practices. Ethics deals with the right or wrong action in a particular circumstance by raising the question of "what should one do?" Medical ethics is a sub-discipline of ethics that helps the students to make the right decisions or choices within the limited field of medicine. Here, the main thing is to understand that ethics and its sub disciplines start with the notion of the 'other,' and where the concept of "other-ness" comes, there would be questions of right and wrong. Thus, this subject creates a platform for students to understand the ethical values and norms in the medical field.

Now let us look at the foundational principle of medical ethics

- **Autonomy** – respecting the patient's right to make decisions about their own care.
- **Non-maleficence** – "do no harm," avoiding actions that cause unnecessary injury or suffering.
- **Beneficence** – actively working to promote the well-being of patients.
- **Justice** – ensuring fairness in medical decisions, resource distribution, and treatment.

- These principles are **not ranked**; they often need to be balanced against each other.
- In real-world dilemmas (e.g., euthanasia, involuntary treatment, confidentiality), conflicts between principles may force practitioners to prioritize one over another.
- Medical ethics is both **applied** (guiding clinical practice) and **scholarly** (philosophy, sociology, history).

Cultural context matters: different societies may emphasize family or community over individual autonomy

Medical ethics provides a **framework for moral reasoning** in healthcare, especially when laws or clinical guidelines don't give clear answers. It's about finding a balance that respects human dignity across diverse cultural and religious settings.

Now let us look in to the **historical development and broadening scope of medical ethics**.

5.5.1 Historical Roots

- **Thomas Percival (1803):** First formal use of the term *medical ethics*, outlining professional expectations.
- **1847 Code of Ethics:** Adapted from Percival's work, shaping early professional standards.
- **Hippocratic Oath:** Ancient foundation emphasizing physician obligations, later expanded by professional societies.

5.5.2 Evolution of Focus

- **Early stage:** Concerned mainly with physician duties and codes of conduct.
- **Modern stage:** Expanded into a wide field of moral and justice issues in health, healthcare, and related domains.
- **Bioethics:** Sometimes used interchangeably, though originally broader (including ecological concerns).

5.5.3 Core Issues in Doctor–Patient Relationship

- **Consent to treatment**
- **Truth-telling vs. paternalism**
- **Confidentiality**
- **Duty to treat**

Medical ethics has shifted from **professional codes** to a **multidimensional field** that addresses dilemmas across life stages, cultural contexts, and emerging technologies. It now requires balancing individual rights with collective responsibilities, and physician obligations with broader social justice concerns.

Now regarding the **practical pillars of medical ethics: confidentiality**. Let us see the important points.

5.5.4 Confidentiality in Medical Ethics

- **Traditional view:** A near-absolute duty — physicians must not disclose patient information.
- **Primary care challenges:**
  - Physicians often treat multiple family/community members.
  - Third parties may request access to medical records.
- **Legal protections:** Patient–physician privilege prevents disclosure even under oath in court.

- **Practical definition:**

    - Doctors must safeguard all information obtained during treatment.

  Often formalized through confidentiality agreements
    - Often formalized through confidentiality agreements.

- **Patient trust:**
    - Patients share sensitive information daily.
    - If confidentiality is doubted, patients may withhold vital details.
    - Protecting privacy is essential for effective care.
- **Ethical right:** Every individual has the right to keep personal and medical information private.

Why Confidentiality Matters

- **Trust-building:** Without it, the therapeutic relationship collapses.
- **Patient autonomy:** Protects the individual's control over personal information.
- **Justice:** Ensures fairness by preventing misuse of sensitive data.
- **Beneficence & non-maleficence:** Encourages full disclosure, enabling better care while avoiding harm.

Privacy vs. Confidentiality

- **Privacy** → Concerns the *person*. It's the right of an individual to keep their medical records and identity protected from public release.
- **Confidentiality** → Concerns the *data*. It's the obligation of healthcare providers to keep medical information private between patient and physician. Confidentiality is essentially an *extension of privacy*.

Key Points on Confidentiality

- **Consent is central**: Patient information should not be disclosed without explicit consent.
- **Risks of breach**:
    - Case studies in journals (though identities are anonymized).
    - Insurance companies, labs, and researchers often require access to records, making absolute secrecy difficult.
- **Legal protections**: Patients can take legal action if identifiable medical information is disclosed without consent.

Trust factor: If patients fear breaches, they may withhold sensitive information, undermining care

- Just as **confidentiality** protects patient trust by safeguarding information, **truth-telling** protects trust by ensuring transparency.
- Both principles reinforce the ethical bond between physician and patient.
- Together, they highlight the shift in medical ethics from paternalism (doctor decides what's best) to respect for patient autonomy and rights.
- According to deontological theory, the rightness and wrongness of an action depend upon these three maxims. If an action satisfies these three maxims, then that action is morally right, if it does not satisfy then these three principles then it is morally wrong. In medical ethics, these two approaches (utilitarianism and deontological) play an important role in the decision making. Kantian approach is very relevant in the medical ethics as we should respect autonomy and dignity of a person. Utilitarian approach is also important in the medical care because it gives us rational capacity to make decision for larger people or a whole society.

5.6 MEDIA ETHICS

- A branch of applied ethics that deals with moral issues in **acquisition, preparation, storage, and presentation of information**.
- Media's role: reporting and evaluating events that affect society (politics, crime, corruption, social affairs).

- **Impartiality** is the hallmark of media ethics — ensuring fairness and objectivity in reporting.

- Just as medical ethics emphasizes **confidentiality, autonomy, beneficence, and justice**, media ethics emphasizes **truth, impartiality, and responsibility**.
- Both fields highlight how ethical principles guide professional conduct and protect public trust.

Media ethics ensures that information is handled responsibly, truthfully, and impartially, just as medical ethics ensures that patient care is conducted with respect, fairness, and trust. Both are examples of applied ethics — philosophy put into practice in professional domains.

Extending the study of **media ethics** by focusing on neutrality, ideological influences, and the psychosocial impact of media, especially on children. Let's break it down:

5.6.1 Neutrality in Journalism

- Journalists are expected to be **neutral observers**.
- They should avoid making **evaluative judgments** in reporting.
- Reporting can produce multiple legitimate accounts of events, not always reducible to one consistent narrative.
- News reports inevitably rest on **moral, social, and political principles**, sometimes shaped by socio-economic structures or ideological beliefs that may not be open to critical questioning.

5.6.2 Influence of Media on Children

- Media has a **profound impact on psychosocial development**.
- Age-appropriate exposure is crucial across forms like television, radio, music, video games, and the internet.
- **Aristotle's catharsis theory**: Dramatic depictions can release emotions safely, preventing harm if those emotions were expressed in real life.

- **20th century media evolution**:
    - Early 1900s: Newspapers and radio (limited access for children).
    - Post-1940s: Television, recorded music, videotapes, electronic games, interactive software, and eventually the internet.

5.6.3.1 Positive Educational Impact

- Television became a milestone in combining **education and entertainment**.
- Educators, psychologists, and child development experts collaborated to design strategies that engaged children.
- **Sesame Street (1969)** was the pioneering program blending learning with entertainment, widely celebrated for its impact.

Media ethics emphasizes **neutrality and impartiality in reporting**, while also recognizing the **powerful influence of media on society and child development**. The ethical responsibility of media professionals extends beyond truth-telling to considering the **social consequences of media exposure**.